

FINANCE MINISTRY

THE BUDGET MAKERS

The start of FY26 has heralded a new team of top officers in the finance ministry. Each of the secretaries will have to hit the ground running

BY SURABHI

► **AFTER A WAIT** of one and a half months, the crucial department of revenue in the finance ministry has got a new full-time secretary with the appointment of Arvind Shrivastava, who was till now serving as Additional Secretary, Prime Minister's Office. A 1994 batch IAS officer of the Karnataka cadre, Shrivastava, takes over from Economic Affairs Secretary Ajay Seth, who held additional charge after Tuhin Kanta Pandey was appointed as Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) Chairperson on February 27.

14 | Along with Shrivastava, the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi has brought in three more new faces in the North Block, including secretaries in the departments of expenditure and public enterprises as well as an Officer on Special Duty (OSD) for the Department of Economic Affairs. Former Civil Aviation Secretary Vumlungmang Vualnam has been appointed as Expenditure Secretary while K.

Moses Chalai, who was Secretary, Inter State Council Secretariat has been appointed Secretary, Department of Public Enterprises, taking over from DIPAM secretary Arunish Chawla, who held additional charge.

Anuradha Thakur, who was serving as Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, will take over as Secretary of the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) when Seth retires on June 30. Thakur will be the first woman to helm the DEA and one of the few female secretaries in the finance ministry. Previously Sushma Nath, who was appointed as Expenditure Secretary way back in 2008, had become the country's first woman Finance Secretary. Later in 2015, Anjali Chib Duggal was appointed as Secretary, Department of Financial Services. The appointments are a part of a major bureaucratic reshuffle with over 20 changes undertaken as the government filled up several secretary-level vacancies. It has also brought in successors who will take over as the current serving secretaries superannuate.

Vandana Gurnani who was Secretary (Coordination), Cabinet Secretariat has been appointed Labour Secretary. Rajesh Agarwal who is Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce has been posted as Special Secretary in the department and will take charge as Secretary once the current incumbent Sunil Barthwal retires on September 30. Each of these officers will have their plates full, from Day 1. A meeting of the Goods and Services Tax Council is pending, and the new Revenue Secretary will have to take charge. As OSD in DEA, Thakur, will have to work closely with Seth to understand the nuances of the job that requires constant modifying of economic policies and keeping abreast of global and domestic developments. For now, the officials have their tasks cut out. **BT**



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